

Geography

U.S.





About the Course

Join the Page family as they travel from California to Washington, D.C. While this story is set in the U.S.A., the point of the book is really to explore basic geography concepts such as landforms, water bodies, maps, and regions, so it is suitable for students from any nation. Students use the globe, atlases, and models. Students also make models and draw maps of places important to them, such as their neighborhood.



Placement & Combining Tips

This course progresses chronologically over two years. Students who did not take Geography Foundations may wish to incorporate those lessons into the afternoons. This course is intended to follow Grade 2; however, the levels may be reversed in order to combine students.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
3	Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.) 2 times/week 20 min	50 Adventures in the 50 States Cross Country: Geography for Children Grandma Gatewood Hikes the Appalachian Trail United States Atlas 7th Ed. Student World Atlas 6th Ed.

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.)				
Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.)		Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.)		



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.

Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.)

☐ Print the maps needed for some of the future lessons. You will find the map links in the prep section of each lesson.

☐ Print the 5th edition map PDF linked below in the Quick Links section for lessons that use economic symbols. (not in the 6th edition of the U.S. atlas)

☐ Check the Appendix for tips on creating geography models and relief maps.



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.)



50 Adventures in the 50 States



Cross Country: Geography for Children



Grandma Gatewood Hikes the Appalachian Trail



United States Atlas 7th Ed.



Student World Atlas 6th Ed.



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

∞ [View Supply List Details](#)

Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.)



Globe



Household Items - Geography: Grade 3



Quick Links

Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.)

∞ [Extra Helpings](#)

∞ [Appendix: Geography Models](#)

∞ [5th Edition U.S. Map PDF](#)

∞ [Foundations \(See Section 16: Geography\)](#)

Click THIS text
or scan the QR
code for links.



Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.)

How To Teach

	Overview The steps below are generally true for most geography lessons. Sometimes several lessons might build together or focus on a particular area (like Map Work).
	Introduce Through questions, observations, an activity, or recalling the last lesson, introduce the topic for the day.
	Map Questions Answer questions on the map or on making your own maps.
	Read Read the day's passage out loud or have the student read independently.
	Narrate Have students retell the passage either orally or in writing. They may want to use maps or pictures to tell back.
	Map Work The lesson may contain more map work as students make their own maps or add to ongoing maps.

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Term 1

WEEK 1 20m Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.) - Lesson 1

Introduction

Materials: Cross-Country, U.S. Atlas

→ INTRO

What do you remember from last year's readings? (You can read the titles of sections or show a few illustrations from last year's readings to help.)

Let's look at the map in the front of the Cross-Country book. What do you notice? Do you see the red line? Remember that this book is about a family that travels along that line (route) across the United States.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Map Resource: Inside front of Cross-Country

1. Locate Los Angeles. Put your finger on it, and then trace with your finger the red line across the United States to Washington, D.C.
2. Locate Denver, Colorado. Our journey will start just east of Denver, but let's find out a little bit about the area before we read.

Map Resource: United States Atlas "The West: The Region" and "The West: Physical Map" p.126-127, 128

1. First, locate Colorado on the Physical Map, and then find the outline of Colorado on the Region map.
2. What do you notice about the terrain in the middle of Colorado? (Hopefully, you notice that the mountains end suddenly. You could start on the west coast and run your finger eastward to mid-Colorado, asking what changes there.)
3. On the Physical Map, try to find a label for the region in eastern Colorado that extends from Montana to Texas. (Great Plains)

Map Resource: United States Atlas "The Physical United States: Climate" p.10-11

1. Locate Colorado.
2. Using the map legend, what can you tell about the climate in Colorado?
3. How does it change from the western side to the eastern side of the state? (Cooler and wetter toward the west. The eastern part is more dry.)

WEEK 1 20m Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.) - Lesson 2

The Great Plains

Materials: Cross-Country, U.S. Atlas, My U.S. Map

PREP: Print Map: "My U.S. Map" (blank U.S. map) or use the one you made last year.

∞ Map Link: blank U.S. Map

→ INTRO

Have you ever read Little House on the Prairie? What do you think the prairie looks like? (If needed, have students study the picture on p.61 of Cross-Country and discuss what they see.)

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Map Resource: United States Atlas "The Physical United States: Physical Map" p.8-9

1. Locate Colorado.
2. Look at the map legend to identify the vegetation in eastern Colorado.
3. What do you think grassland will look like?
4. Locate your home state and your general location. (You may look at p.14-15 if needed to help find your state.)
5. How does the vegetation of your home compare with that of eastern Colorado?

• TAKE A GEOGRAPHY WALK

Look for the vegetation found during Map Questions from today's lesson.

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Term 1

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Cross-Country

p.62-63 "Mother and Father" - "made the cattle fat."

→ MAP WORK

□ Map Resource: My U.S. Map

1. Add the Blank US Map to your geography journal if not in there from last year.
2. Add the title "My US Map" (making sure the title does not cover any states).
3. Label Colorado if not already labeled from last year.
4. Draw a cow in the eastern half of the state.

WEEK 2 □ 20m Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.) - Lesson 3 *The Great Plains (cont.)*

□ Materials: Cross-Country, U.S. Atlas, My U.S. Map

→ INTRO

We read yesterday that the Pages drove on straight roads. Why do you think the roads were straight? (flat land) Do you remember what the roads were like in the mountains? ("winding" and "ran up and down" on p.42 of Cross-Country)

→ MAP QUESTIONS

□ Map Resource: United States Atlas "The Physical United States: Physical Map" p.8-9

1. Locate the Great Plains.
2. Through which states does it run? (Montana, North Dakota, South Dakota, Wyoming, Nebraska, Colorado, Kansas, Oklahoma, Texas, and New Mexico)

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Cross-Country

p.64 "In a little town" - "very much alike."

→ MAP WORK

□ Map Resource: My U.S. Map

Similar to the Rocky Mountains label from last year, label the Great Plains so that the label slants across the map to mimic the plains stretching across multiple states. Be careful not to cover up Kansas, since that is the next stop for the Pages.

WEEK 2 □ 20m Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.) - Lesson 4 *Reading Maps*

□ Materials: Student World Atlas, Cross-Country

→ NOTE

The information in this lesson is a refresher from last year.

→ MAP QUESTIONS

□ Map Resource: Student World Atlas "United States: Political" p.65
Based on the global grid, which direction is north on this map?

□ Map Resource: Inside front of Cross-Country

1. What is to the west of Los Angeles? (Pacific Ocean)
2. Which ocean is near Washington, D.C.? (Atlantic Ocean)
3. Is the Atlantic Ocean to the east or west of Washington, D.C.? (east)
4. If we travel from Los Angeles to Washington, D.C., which direction would you travel? (east)
5. Where do you live? Which direction would you travel to get to Los Angeles? To get to Washington, D.C.? To get to Denver, Colorado?

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

6. Come up with your own questions to give more practice on directions.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Student World Atlas p.8
Direction and Scale

WEEK 3 20m Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.) - Lesson 5

Grids and Maps

Materials: local map, Student World Atlas

PREP: Today you will need a map of your local area (or a state map, if the city cannot be found). If no options exist, print a map from a web mapping service (like Google Maps or OpenStreetMap) and draw your own grid.

→ INTRO

Do you remember that globes and maps also have a grid?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

Student World Atlas p.8
“Reading Maps” and all captions—Latitude, Longitude, and Global Grid

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Map Resource: Your local map

1. Spend some time calling out grid cells; for example, “Locate G4.”
2. When this is mastered, move on to specific places with the following types of questions.
3. What grid cell is your home in?
4. Where is your church, grocery store, bank, park, etc.? What grid cell is that in?

→ NOTE

Save your map for later lessons.

WEEK 3 20m Geography: Grade 3 (U.S.) - Lesson 6

Wheat Country

Materials: Cross-Country, My U.S. Map

→ MAP QUESTIONS

Map Link: Topography of the U.S.

1. Familiarize yourself with the color ramp in the lower right corner.
2. Locate Colorado and Kansas.
3. What do you notice about elevation as you travel east across Colorado and Kansas? (elevation decreases)
4. What do you think Kansas will look like?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.65-66 “Flat land” - “what threshing means.”

→ MAP WORK

Map Resource: My U.S. Map
Label Kansas.